

the bumps around the streets of Monte Carlo and had to increase the car's ride height, sacrificing lap time, as modern F1 cars perform better with a rear ride height closer to the track for maximum downforce.

Leclerc was fastest in FP2 on Friday evening and FP3 on Saturday morning. Although Oscar Piastri and McLaren gave Ferrari a good fight in qualifying, Leclerc eeked pole position by just under a tenth of a second faster than Piastri. Carlos Sainz and Lando Norris closed out the second row.

On Sunday, within moments of the race start, there was a massive crash involving Haas driver Kevin Magnussen and Red Bull's Sergio Perez when the latter tried to make a move on the opening lap. The collision also collected an innocent Nico Hulkenberg in the other Haas, forcing the race to be stopped.

It was the perfect gift for the other Ferrari of Sainz, who was involved in a minor scuffle with Piastri and the resulting contact, giving him a puncture. Though Sainz slumped down the order, the fact that Kick Sauber's Zhou Guanyu did not cross the first sector of the track meant the cars restarted the race in the original order.

During a red flag, mechanics are allowed to repair the cars, meaning Sainz got a new set of tyres and

Indy 500

On the same day as the Monaco GP, there was another historical race happening across the Atlantic with the 108th running of the Indianapolis 500. The iconic race saw Team Penske's Josef Newgarden take his second Indy500 win in as many years, becoming only the sixth driver to do so. H lio Castroneves was the last driver to win the prestigious race back-to-back in 2001 and 2002.

In a thrilling end to the race, Newgarden lost the lead into turn one on the last lap of the race to Arrow McLaren's Pat O'Ward, but regained it a few corners later to take the honours at The Brickyard.



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reclaimed his third place on the grid. Once the race restarted, it was the usual Monaco procession without many overtakes. The fact that most cars swapped tyres at the red flag meant they did not have to make another stop in the race, thus further reducing any scope for strategic variance.

Leclerc comfortably led Piastri (who got his first podium of the year) and his teammate Sainz to a famous home victory.

It was the first time in F1 history that the top ten drivers finished in the same position they started in, illustrating how difficult it is to make a pass.



AFP

Moto GP

Meanwhile, in the world of two-wheel racing, reigning champion Francesco Bagnaia (left) delivered two sublime weekends at the Catalan and Italian GPs, posting commanding wins to reduce his points deficit to championship leader Jorge Martin.

The first race of the double-header started on the wrong foot for Bagnaia. The Ducati factory team rider made a costly mistake in the Sprint Race at Barcelona, crashing from the lead and giving home hero Aleix Espargaro, who recently announced his retirement, the win. But Bagnaia made amends on Sunday in Barcelona by beating Martin in a straight fight, taking the lead with six laps left in the race to get his third win of the season.

At Mugello, the two-time champion put on a dominant display in both the Sprint and Grand Prix by doing the double relatively easily at his and Ducati's home race. It was his first sprint win of the season, and he drastically cut into Martin's lead, now 18 points, with 13 races left.

Meanwhile, on the Monday after the Italian GP, there was a shock move in the rider market when Martin announced he would join Aprilia Racing in 2025. The Prima Pramac rider has been with the satellite Ducati team since 2021. Having finished runner-up last year, Martin was hoping to take the second seat at the factory Ducati team alongside Bagnaia, and it seemed the deal was close to being signed. But in the eleventh hour, it seems to have fallen through. Martin's move has now opened the door for six-time champion Marc Marquez to take the coveted second factory Ducati seat.